Payday Spire: a 4-week school pilot

A money lesson students play: their first working year in the UAE as a card battle. For schools, universities and bank or fintech youth and CSR programmes. Contact: [EMAIL] · Play: [ITCH_URL] · Code: [GITHUB_URL] · 2-minute video: [VIDEO_URL]

The problem

Young people meet their first salary, first credit card and first pay-later offer at the same time. Card interest, an empty emergency fund and sale-driven spending are easy to explain and hard to feel. UAE banks already fund school financial-education sessions (for example Dubai Islamic Bank: about 50 schools, up to 4,000 students, 2023), but these programmes are often measured by attendance and satisfaction rather than by what students then do (The National, 16 Jan 2026).

The solution

Twelve months, twelve short card battles. Bills, surprise costs, sales and last month's card bill are the enemies; money habits are the cards. Putting a bill on the card costs nothing today, then comes back next month as a card bill and lets Impulse buys into the deck. Students feel the rule before they read it.

What already works (free, today)

Free web game	Runs in any browser, phone or laptop. No install, no account, no server, no names.
Teacher dashboard	`teacher.html`: paste the students' result codes, get a class summary, the three topics to discuss first, year goals reached, and a printable pilot results page.
45-minute lesson	`docs/lesson_plan.md`: timed steps, a year preview for the teacher, five discussion questions with the points of a good answer, a 30-minute version.
Arabic	Game and dashboard in English and Arabic (right to left). UAE setting: AED, Ramadan, Eid, sadaqah, zakat, qard hasan.
Accessibility	Keyboard play, 3 text sizes, reduce motion, captions for every sound, colour cues always with an icon and a word; 0 contrast failures in our automated WCAG 2.2 AA audit.

The 4-week pilot

Week	In class	What the teacher sends us
1	Lesson 1 (45 min) with class code A (one goal for all: `?goal=`). Students play one year, then the class talk.	Results CSV from the dashboard.
2	Students replay the same year (class or home, about 15 min) and try to beat their last run.	Results CSV.
3	Lesson 2 with a new class code B, same goal: a new year, same rules. Does the habit carry over?	Results CSV and the pilot results page.
4	Wrap-up: each student writes one habit to keep. A 15-minute call with the teacher.	Five short teacher questions (time, fit, what to change).

What the school needs: one class of 15 to 30 students aged about 15 to 22, a device per student, a projector, and 2 lessons plus one short replay.

What we measure, and how

All numbers come from the dashboard's **Download results (CSV)** button: one row per student, no names, no device or account data.

Measure	How it is read
Quick guesses, month 1 and year end	Two money questions after month 1, asked again with new numbers at year end: right answers per student, and the share who did better.
Card bill not paid in full	Share of students who left a card bill short at least once. Compared between code A and code B.
Emergency fund goal	Share who ended the year with a month of living costs set aside.
Interest and fees	Average paid, and share who paid none.
Grades and goal	Steady year / You made it / Card frozen; share who finished 12 months; share who reached their year goal (sample class: 25%).
Teacher fit	Minutes used, and the five teacher answers.

Limits we state up front: two quick guesses are a sign, not a validated test. A fuller pre/post check is written with a financial-literacy educator in the funded plan (phase P2).

Price (assumptions, not quotes)

- **Pilot:** free.
- **School licence after the pilot:** about AED 1,500 per school per year (assumption) for scenario packs, saved class reports and one code per class.
- **Bank or fintech sponsor:** the sponsor pays school licences for the schools it supports, or a white-label edition with its own name and product cards, priced per project.
- **Reference prices are from the US market, not the UAE:** PersonalFinanceLab lists sponsored school licences at USD 895 to 5,995 a year and white-label finance games at USD 12,000 to 20,000 a year; Stock-Trak lists sponsor packages at USD 1,425 (100 accounts) to USD 12,000 (1,000 accounts). No school or bank has bought Payday Spire yet.

Contact

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Sources: dib.ae news 7 Nov 2023; thenationalnews.com 16 Jan 2026; personalfinancelab.com/?p=23858; stocktrak.com/corporate-sponsorship (all read 10 Nov 2026).